

Corrected Sandy Bridge

Intel is shipping out corrected core logic chips for the Sandy Bridge processors. These chips have the new B3 stepping

GTX 590 coming

All indications point towards a monster dual GPU, GeForce 590 GPU soon. Evidently one of NVIDIA's beta drivers list a card called the "GeForce GTX 590"

Notebook test

icipating in any "notebook comparison tests". We have been unsuccessful in trying to convince them otherwise, and cannot understand the reason behind it.

Features, build, etc.

When you're shopping for a notebook under ₹40,000, it's important to get your priorities right. Do you want a performance machine, or do you want something for office work and browsing? Additionally, is it something you will be carting around a lot? While you will typically not get 12.1 and 13.3-inch notebooks within this price range owing to the costs involved with shrinking the space available for components, there are plenty of 14-inch options, along with the much larger 15.6-inch options. So while a larger display might be tempting, it also tips the scales and makes it inconvenient to cart around.

There's a general thumb rule here – portability means 14-inch and smaller displays, with some exceptions. Some 14.1-inch notebooks might be too thick and bulky, and weigh more. Lightweight materials also add to costs, which is why ultra-portables are so expensive.

HOW WE TESTED

Over the past five years, we've more or less tuned our test processes and testing benchmarks to achieve a fine balance between fairness and subjectivity. Obviously, testing a notebook is not the same as testing a graphics card, and some subjectivity is required – the human factor, if you will. This time round we made one very major change. We figured that our Bazaar ratings have an extra value called build, whereas for our tests, we only have features and performance, with build typically rated as a part of features. Now build can be expanded to mean usability also, after all isn't it the thought process behind building something that dictates how usable (or not) a device is? So this time, our test has been divided into three parts – features, performance, and build and usability. This third part is a breakaway from the first, and henceforth will be a chunk of all tests that contain subjective elements, like cellphones, cameras, notebooks and PMPs. We might even add to this list.

Under features we list all the specifications, and characteristics of the notebooks. Not all these points are rated or given scores. For example, we're not concerned with the processor model number, which would directly affect performance, but we are concerned with the storage capacity. Similarly, we don't give extra points for discrete graphics, because that will affect other scores, however, we will rate the number of USB and FireWire ports. Usability consisted of a lot of factors, including keypad layout and feel, trackpad feel and accuracy, shortcut keys, ergonomics during usage etc.

Finally, for performance we have two benchmark suites – PC Mark Vantage and 3D Mark 2006. We also use CineBench and are now using the latest version 11.5. Battery life of each notebook is tested by playing a video using VLC player, while turning off all power saving features, including screensavers and low-power states. The tests rated on a scale of 10 are typically subjective. Tests like DivX encoding and file transfers are measured in seconds, and with such scores, the lower the better as lower scores denote the task finished quicker. Lastly, we used a couple of games, Doom 3 and Far Cry 2. The former is an old game that we run at 800 x 600 pixels, this is to test the suitability of a notebook as a casual gaming machine, while Far Cry 2, a newer game, is run at a more demanding resolution of 1024 x 768 pixels – this simulates a more game-oriented user. For gaming notebooks (none in this test were), we use games like Crysis and Call Of Pripyat to judge performance.



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